

Managing a Return to Work

Welcoming a return, gently and safely

4 psychology approaches · tips & guidance — by EvaTalk

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BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Welcoming a return, gently and safely

After a long absence — burnout, illness, a life event — a team member's return is a delicate moment. Poorly handled, it can lead to a relapse; well prepared, it secures the person and the team.

This guide helps you understand what the return stirs up, adopt a human stance, and prepare it concretely — with the right channels.

Your intention

A return you have to support: _____

The 4 approaches

This guide works your topic through 4 complementary psychology lenses. Read, do the exercises, fill the workbook — at your own pace.

Psychodynamic — understand the root.

CBT — ease the negative thoughts.

Humanistic — reconcile with yourself.

Systemic — act on your environment.

What it stirs (on both sides)

For the manager: awkwardness, fear of 'doing it wrong' or 'reopening wounds'. For the person: fear of judgment, of not coping, sometimes shame.

Recognizing these emotions avoids missteps (acting 'as if nothing happened', or conversely surveilling).

Example

Uneasy, Marc avoided the subject on a colleague's return — who felt ignored. A simple 'good to have you back, how shall we organize this?' would have sufficed.

My awkwardness

What makes you uneasy about this return? What are you afraid of doing wrong?

On their side

What might the person dread on returning? How to ease it?

→ *Naming the awkwardness avoids missteps — on both sides.*

The thoughts that interfere

‘We must act as if nothing happened’, ‘I mustn’t mention it’, ‘they must quickly be back to 100%’: these thoughts lead either to denial or to pressure.

Softening them opens a fair welcome.

Example

Sure he had to ‘pick up exactly as before’, Nia imposed too hard a pace. Adjusting averted a relapse.

Thoughts journal

Note: the interfering thought · a fairer version (e.g. ‘I can ask the person what would help’).

Return ≠ immediate 100%

Write why a gradual return protects better than a ‘full-on’ one.

→ *A good return happens at an adjusted pace — not 100% at once.*

A human, respectful stance

Welcoming without surveilling, respecting the pace and confidentiality, treating the person as a capable adult: that's what restores trust.

The person shares what they want — your role is to welcome, not investigate.

Example

By letting his team member decide what to share, Léa created a climate of trust — and a calm return.

My welcome

Prepare a simple, warm welcome line (without intrusion).

Respect the pace

What are you ready to adjust to respect their pace (workload, hours, goals)?

→ *Welcoming without surveilling, respecting the pace — that's trust.*

Preparing the return concretely

Concretely: anticipate with HR and occupational health (accommodations, a gradual return if possible), plan a welcome check-in, adjust workload and goals, ensure regular follow-up, and — if the absence was work-related — act on the causes to prevent relapse.

Occupational health steers the medical side: lean on them.

Example

By preparing the return with occupational health and a gradual restart, Sofia let her team member come back sustainably.

My preparation

Note: whom to involve (HR, occupational health) · possible accommodations · the welcome check-in.

Prevent relapse

If the absence was work-related: which cause can you act on?

→ *A return prepared with the right channels protects the person and the team.*

Practical tips & advice

Tips & advice

- Prepare the return in advance (HR, occupational health, accommodations).
- Welcome simply and humanely, without overplaying or surveilling.
- Respect confidentiality: the person shares what they want.
- Favor a gradual return and adjusted goals.
- Hold regular, caring check-ins; if the absence was work-related, act on the causes.
- For medical matters, occupational health steers.

To fill in

My return preparation

Element (channel, accommodation)	Action

My follow-up

When	What I adjust

PLAN

Your 4-week plan

Week 1 — Understand what this return stirs up.

Week 2 — Soften the thoughts that interfere.

Week 3 — Adopt a human, respectful stance.

Week 4 — Prepare the return (channels, restart, follow-up).

Your plan in 3 lines

- My welcome line:
- What I adjust to respect their pace:
- The cause I act on (if work-related):

TO CLOSE

A prepared, respectful return protects the person and the team.

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